

BRITISH AIRWAYS

STAGE 2 ASSESSMENT — PREP PACK

JAMES GEORGE · FRIDAY ASSESSMENT AT BA WATERSIDE · JULY 2026

Part 1 · Assessment Day Guide | Part 2 · Interview & Nine Competencies | Part 3 · BA & Skyborne Fact Sheets

Your one-line narrative — every answer should sound like this person:

“Aviation started for me at 13 with my grandad’s home-built gliders, became four years of gliding at Welland, then a PPL at Cabaero — 70 hours and a night rating in progress — funded by working as a lifeguard and an HGV mechanic’s assistant. Speedbird is the first route to a BA flight deck that doesn’t depend on family money, and I’ve spent five years proving I’ll do the work.”

Where You Are in the Process

STAGE	WHAT IT IS	STATUS
Stage 1	Online application + BA aptitude/psychometric testing + verbal speaking activity	✓ Passed
Stage 2	Skyborne online testing → in-person assessment day at BA Waterside → online interview with Skyborne (mid–late Aug)	← Friday
Stage 3	BA final assessment, also at Waterside: group exercise + multitasking half-day, then a full individual day (“Speedy” interviews, competency exercise, reflective interview, Heritage Centre tour)	Sept–Oct

Venue is BA’s Waterside HQ (Harmondsworth, next to Heathrow) even though this is the flight-school stage — Skyborne and FTEJerez run slots there (~7–16 candidates each) with BA reps present. This year the competency interview is normally NOT on the day — it’s your online Skyborne interview in August. Prepare it anyway; formats vary and the informal conversations count.

The Day: Two Parts, Three Assessed Exercises

2026-cycle candidate reports (PPRuNe + candidates posting from their days): the day at Waterside is **split into a group session and an individual testing session**, covering the **Eagle capacity test**, a **handling test**, and the **group exercise**. Candidates consistently say BA and the flight schools try to help you be your best — rigorous, not hostile.

1 · Eagle capacity test (BA “Flight Capacity” test)

Game-based simulated cockpit: **respond to ATC instructions, monitor TCAS/traffic, manage system issues**, with **mental maths and data questions** woven through. Measures spatial orientation, hand-eye coordination, divided attention, response time, memory and **stress tolerance**. It loads you until you saturate — everyone saturates; what’s scored is how much you handle and how you degrade.

- **Prioritise ruthlessly:** fly-the-aircraft tasks first; drop secondary items calmly, never freeze — graceful degradation beats perfection then collapse
- Aviate–navigate–communicate in test form — your pan-pan story is this skill
- Your PPL RT fluency parses instructions faster than non-flyers can — a real edge

*Successful cadet: “Maths and physics to GCSE level — they send preparation information through beforehand.” Check inbox **and spam**; work through everything they send.*

GCSE refresher: forces & moments · pressure · speed/distance/time & acceleration · $V=IR$ & power · energy & work · ratios, percentages, fractions (no calculator) · graph reading · unit conversions (kts/mpg/km-h, litres/gallons, ft/m). Your PPL theory covers most of it.

2 · Handling test — your strongest event

A flight-simulator handling assessment, reported **with a partner**, alternating pilot / co-pilot roles: flying instructed changes of **altitude, speed and heading** accurately and smoothly. 70 PPL hours + years of gliding vs candidates who’ve never touched controls. Fly it like an instrument student, not a gamer:

- **Small corrections, then wait** — a jet sim responds slowly; change, hold, observe. Don’t chase needles
- **Attitude first** — set the attitude/power for the target, then fine-tune; verbalise (“climbing to 4,000, speed 210”)
- **Fly the instruction exactly** — told 180 kts, hold 180, not 185; accuracy and workload management are the marks, not flair
- **Be a great co-pilot too** — monitor actively, support if invited, never take over. The pairing is deliberate: CRM is watched in both seats, and you’re marked independently — your partner doing well costs you nothing

3 · Group exercise

*Successful cadet: “The group task isn’t about the actual task — they mark how you come across and communicate. **Listening is the key thing.**”*

- **Claim timekeeper in the first minute** — exact words: “I’ll monitor the time and keep the group updated.” Then do it: “we’re halfway” · “5 minutes left — shall we start converging?”
- **Listen above everything** — build the decision from people’s actual points; consensus that pleases the group scores.
- **Bring quiet people in by name:** “We haven’t heard from you yet — what do you think about the problem?” Highest-scoring move available.
- **Cage a dominator gently** — redirect, don’t confront: “That’s one option — before we settle, can we hear what [quiet person] thinks?”
- **Contribute early** (first two minutes) · **build on others** (“I like Sarah’s point — could we combine it with...”) · **concede gracefully**, state reasoning once, commit to the group decision.

- **Never** talk over people, dismiss ideas, or fight to “win” — one domineering moment can fail the exercise.

After the day · Online Skyborne interview (~45 min, STAR) — mid-late August

Pass Friday and the next step is an online 1:1 with Skyborne. See Part 2. Big themes this cycle: **“What does integrity mean to you?”** (asked early, consistently) · why BA / why Speedbird / why Skyborne / why short-haul · teamwork & speaking up (CRM) · mistake + learning · calm under pressure · customer service · company knowledge.

The Waiting Room Is Part of the Assessment

Cadet’s advice: the big waiting area is daunting, but **go and talk to people — it’s a massive part**. Reps circulate all day, and a successful cadet was later asked — in the Stage 3 reflective interview — a question you can only answer if you built the habit on Friday:

“Who do you think should get through from this process, and why?”

Answer with real names and observed behaviours in competency language — “Tom brought the group back on task twice without talking over anyone — that’s who I’d want in the other seat.” Be generous: praising a rival convincingly *is* the answer. Never “me”, never rank yourself, never “everyone”.

So: learn names, ask about their routes into flying, remember one genuine detail about two or three candidates. You are observed all day — warm to candidates, engaged with reps, good questions ready.

Logistics Checklist — Do Before Thursday Night

- ☐ Re-read the invitation: exact venue, arrival time, what to bring (ID/passport, certificates, logbook if requested)
- ☐ Work through any aptitude prep pack they emailed (check spam)
- ☐ Dress: business suit, conservative; polished shoes; airline-standard grooming
- ☐ Plan the journey to **Waterside, Harmondsworth** with a big buffer — M25/M4 traffic, or Elizabeth line to Heathrow then bus/taxi — arrive 30–40 min early
- ☐ Print the invitation + photo ID
- ☐ Prepare 2–3 questions for them (“What distinguishes cadets who thrive at Vero Beach?”)
- ☐ Eagle-style capacity practice Mon–Thu (SkyTest or similar) + 20 min/day no-calculator mental maths, **stop Thursday evening** — sleep beats one more session
- ☐ A session or two on a home sim flying precise altitude/speed/heading changes on instruments — smoothness practice for the handling test
- ☐ Say the “why BA” and integrity answers out loud three times
- ☐ Proper breakfast; water and a snack — capacity tests punish low blood sugar

The Nine Pilot Competencies — Good AND Bad Example Each

Cadet's method: write a good and a bad example for each of the nine ICAO competencies in a **notebook** — one page per competency, STAR bullets only. A “bad” example is only bad if you can't show what changed; every one below ends in a corrected behaviour.

COMPETENCY	GOOD EXAMPLE	BAD / DEVELOPMENTAL EXAMPLE
1. Application of Knowledge	PPL theory applied in real nav planning; explaining the no-diving rule via spinal-injury mechanics	Early rote checklist knowledge without the <i>why</i> — the oil-limit moment taught reasoning from the system, not the number
2. Procedures & Regulations	Oil at lower limit → refused to depart, topped up, lost the slot	Initially tried to salvage a non-stable approach before going around — now stable-approach criteria decide, not ego
3. Communication	Pan-pan — early, calm, structured; de-escalating the angry parent	Nav error: told ATC only <i>after</i> re-fixing position — now report uncertainty early
4. Flight Path — Automation	Disciplined use of glass-cockpit aids; instruments cross-checked against the visual picture	Followed the moving map over the chart — screen overconfidence fed the checkpoint error. Now: raw-data cross-check every checkpoint
5. Flight Path — Manual	Glider thermal-collapse: energy management, no engine, accurate conservative circuit under stress	The high-and-fast final itself — poor energy management; fixed by setting up earlier + a defined go-around gate
6. Leadership & Teamwork	School gala zone redistribution — seamless, no interruption	Early lifeguarding: stayed in my zone too literally, didn't monitor the team — gala taught whole-operation scanning
7. Problem Solving & Decisions	Thermal collapse: options identified before needed, committed decisively; the go-around call	Get-there-itis nav error: pressed on on an assumption — now pause and verify the moment reality diverges from plan
8. Situational Awareness	Spotting the drowning child from posture change; flagging cloud vs the CAS boundary	Making the landscape fit the chart — the definitive SA failure, owned, with the verbalise-checkpoints fix
9. Workload Management	Aviate–navigate–communicate sequencing in the weather diversion — one problem at a time	Early solo circuits: everything at once on final until the approach fell apart — learned to shed low-priority tasks and fly first

△ Three right-column entries (rote knowledge, zone-only scanning, early-circuit overload) are plausible reconstructions of typical learning moments — replace each with your real memory before Friday so every answer is genuinely true.

Core STAR Answers

NEAR-CERTAIN EARLY QUESTION

Q1. “What does integrity mean to you?”

“Integrity is doing the right thing when it costs you something and nobody would have known otherwise. In aviation: reporting your own errors, refusing to cut corners under time pressure, being honest about your limits.” **Evidence:** oil at the lower limit before a solo nav, tight weather window — flagged it, topped up, lost 20 minutes and the slot. Nobody asked.

“The pre-flight check is a promise to everyone who trusts the aircraft. I’d rather be 20 minutes late and certain than on time and second-guessing myself.”

BA link: integrity is BA’s headline value — a century-old brand carrying 46m passengers survives on crews who choose procedure over convenience unwatched.

Q2. Quick decision in a safety-critical situation — pool rescue (Nene Centre)

Child in distress in the deep end: three whistle blasts, in with the rescue tube, towed to the edge while directing a colleague to clear the pool and stand by the EAP. Incident report + team debrief after.

“Drills exist so that when the real moment arrives you don’t have to think — you act. That’s the mindset I want on a BA flight deck.”

Q3. Calm under pressure — deteriorating weather, solo nav

Cloud base dropping 15 miles out. Aviate—navigate—communicate: straight and level, fuel and position confirmed, pan-pan, vectors to an alternate, safe landing. Instructor: declaring early was good airmanship.

“Structure keeps you safe when pressure is real. I’ve tested that in the air, alone, and it held.”

BA link: Heathrow is the world’s most congested airspace — and the capacity test measures exactly this skill.

Q4. Teamwork — school gala coverage

200 children, four guards; colleague stepped away. Signalled the lead, redistributed zones between three, extended scanning arc, communicated each rotation. “Seamless.”

“Good teams stay aware of the whole team and close gaps before they become problems. That’s a multi-crew cockpit.”

CRM — BA LOVES THIS ONE

Q5. Disagreeing with someone senior — instructor’s routing

Briefed route near a CAS boundary with cloud building west. Raised it specifically: “I’m not fully comfortable with the margin — could we deviate slightly east?” Weather reviewed, track adjusted. The skill wasn’t the reroute — it was the reasoned, calm challenge.

“Something felt wrong and silence would have been the wrong choice. Saying it calmly and accepting the outcome — that’s what CRM actually looks like.”

BA link: BA pioneered European CRM; First Officers are trained to challenge Captains — this is direct evidence of the instinct.

Q6. A mistake with real consequences — nav error, solo cross-country

Misidentified a checkpoint, pressed on making the landscape fit, ended up off-track with tighter margins. Stopped rationalising, re-fixed from railway + reservoir, honest position to ATC, conservative route home. Debrief: “get-there-itis in miniature.” Now: verbalise checkpoints; if it doesn’t match, stop.

“The mistake wasn’t misreading the map — it was continuing rather than admitting I wasn’t certain. I’ve never done that again.”

BA link: BA’s non-punitive reporting culture (ASRs) is built on exactly this behaviour — demonstrated before anyone paid me to have it.

WEIGHTED HIGHER AT BA

Q7. Excellent customer service — nervous returning swimmer

Adult gripping the lane rope, hesitant. On a break: checked in, learned they were returning after years away, practical suggestions, checked in again as they left. Back the next week.

“What people experience depends on whether anyone is paying attention. For a premium airline, that attention is the product.”

Q8. Adapting when the plan changed — thermal collapse at Welland

Lost planned height, no engine. Fallback field identified, margins computed, committed to home, radioed the club early, conservative circuit.

“Rigidly following a dead plan is more dangerous than the change that killed it. Flexibility and structure aren’t opposites — you need both.”

MOTIVATION

Q9. “Why a pilot, and why British Airways?”

Why aviation: ignited at 13 by grandad’s home-built gliders → four years at Welland → PPL with Cabaero, 70 hours, night rating in training. Deliberate at every step. **Why commercial:** multi-crew flying with real passengers is where skill, communication and judgment converge under real stakes. **Why BA:** (1) the Academy itself — the only UK flag carrier removing the £100k barrier entirely; I funded my PPL lifeguarding and turning spanners on HGVs — I’m exactly who that money exists for. (2) Scale and ceiling — A320 out of Heathrow to 787-10s (32 arriving from 2027), A350s, refitted A380s. (3) Standards and heritage — a century of the Speedbird callsign, oneworld founder, wrote European CRM practice. (4) A business worth joining — £2.23bn operating profit 2025, 15.2% margin, £7bn transformation, net zero 2050.

“I’ve been flying since I was 13 and funded every hour myself. Speedbird is the first door to a BA flight deck that opens on merit alone — I’ve spent five years earning the right to walk through it.”

Q10. “Why short-haul first?” / “Five years from now?”

Short-haul: the best training ground in aviation — more sectors, take-offs, landings and real decisions per month than any long-haul roster. **Five years:** established A320 First Officer, spotless record, building toward long-haul as the 787-10s arrive — and mentoring future Speedbird cadets who started where I did.

Q11. “What do you know about the Academy / Skyborne?”

Launched 2023, BA’s first fully funded scheme; 2026: 160 places, £18m (~£100k each — down from 200 in 2025, so this year is more selective). Pathway: Gloucestershire ground school (13 UK CAA exams) → **~6 months at Vero Beach, Florida** — all single-engine flying through CPL + A-UPRT on Piper Warriors/Arrows → UK multi-engine IR on the DA42 → APS MCC → A320 type rating. Pipeline live: June 2026 cohort just arrived at Vero Beach; first cadets already graduated.

REFLECTIVE

Q12. “Who should get through from this process, and why?”

Really a question about you: accurate observation, generosity without insecurity, evidence you engaged. Name real people, one observed behaviour each, framed in competency language (“she managed the time without dominating — workload management and teamwork in one”). Never “me”, never “everyone”.

Delivery notes

- **Write answers in a notebook** — writing fixes them in the head far better than re-reading.
- 90 seconds per story, most of it on **Action**; closing line said as your own thought, never recited.
- **One** fact per answer (£2.23bn, 160 places, 10% SAF) — one is awareness, three is Wikipedia.
- No prepared story? Pause — “let me pick the best example” — and structure STAR aloud. Composure in that moment is the answer.
- Mirror their language: “flight deck” not “cockpit”, “colleagues” not “staff”, **“customers” not “passengers”**.

British Airways — Quick Glance (July 2026)

Company	British Airways plc — principal subsidiary of IAG (formed 2011, BA + Iberia). Sisters: Iberia, Aer Lingus, Vueling, LEVEL. Founding member of oneworld (1999). HQ: Waterside, Harmondsworth.
Leadership	Sean Doyle, Chairman & CEO (rejoined Oct 2020 from Aer Lingus)
Identity	IATA BA · ICAO BAW · callsign Speedbird (1930s Imperial Airways emblem — the academy is named after it). Founded 1974 (BOAC + BEA); heritage to 1919.
FY2025	Operating profit £2,230m (up £182m), 15.2% margin · ~46.7m passengers · 183 destinations
Hubs	Heathrow T5 (+T3) · Gatwick (BA Euroflyer, A320) · London City (BA Cityflyer, E190) — know the mainline / Euroflyer / Cityflyer structure
Brand	“A British Original” (2022) — premium, original thinking, British character

Fleet (~280+ aircraft)

TYPE	COUNT	NOTES
Airbus A320 family (ceo/neo)	Largest	Short-haul workhorse — the fleet Speedbird cadets join first
Airbus A380-800	12	Flagship; being retrofitted, not retired
Airbus A350-1000	18	Newest long-haul flagship
Boeing 777-200ER / -300ER	~40 / ~16	Long-haul backbone
Boeing 787-8 / -9	12 / 18	Dreamliner fleet
Boeing 787-10	32 on order	Deliveries 2027–2030 — the fleet you could grow into

Latest news — attach one to your point, don’t recite

- **Brand-new First class suite** launching mid-2026 on retrofitted **A380s** (up to 110 Club Suites each) — the premium strategy in action
- **£7bn transformation programme:** cabins, IT, operational resilience
- **Network:** St. Louis launched 2026 (27th US route); Cityflyer adding Toulon St-Tropez, Olbia, San Sebastián for summer 2026
- **Speedbird in motion:** June 2026 cohort just arrived at Vero Beach; first cadets already graduated from Skyborne
- **BA Better World:** net zero 2050 · 10% SAF by 2030

Example: “With the A380 retrofit and 32 787-10s from 2027, BA is planning the next two decades of long-haul — the timescale of the career I’m starting.”

Skyborne — Know Your Flight School

UK campuses	Gloucestershire Airport (HQ) and Bournemouth — ground school and IR phases
UK fleet	Diamond DA42-VI twins (G1000 glass cockpit, FADEC) + ALSIM DA42 simulators
US campus — your ~6 months	Vero Beach, Florida: 60+ Piper single- and multi-engine aircraft (Warriors, Arrows, Seminoles), four Redbird MCX-E sims . Fair weather = consistent scheduling year-round — why the whole single-engine phase happens there

Course shape (Speedbird)	1: ATPL theory, 13 UK CAA exams, ~6–8 months (UK) → 2: all single-engine flying through CPL + A-UPRT at Vero Beach , ~6 months → 3: multi-engine IR on the DA42, 4–6 months (UK) → 4: APS MCC ~40 hrs (B737 MAX / A320 sims) → A320 type rating → BA First Officer
Right now (July 2026)	June 2026 Speedbird cohort just arrived at Vero Beach to start flying; a new intake began UK ground school; first-ever Speedbird cadets have completed training
Other partners	BA Speedbird (UK preferred supplier), Jet2 FlightPath, easyJet, Ryanair

Interview drops: “The structure makes sense — Florida’s weather gives uninterrupted consistency exactly when you’re building raw handling skills; then the IR comes home to the UK, where you learn instrument flying in the airspace and weather you’ll actually operate in.” · “I like that the IR is on the DA42’s glass cockpit — the transition to the A320’s automation philosophy starts before the type rating.”

Bonus hook: from grandad’s home-built gliders to a G1000 DA42 — the same fundamentals at every level of technology.

Competencies BA assesses all day — including at lunch

Integrity & professionalism · Teamwork/CRM · Communication · Composure under pressure · Situational awareness · Motivation & commercial awareness · Customer focus